

HERITAGE ATTRACTIONS OF Rajasthan

Forts of Rajasthan

Rajasthan has six forts which are World Heritage Sites, cited by UNESCO as 'Hill Forts of Rajasthan': Chittorgarh, Kumbhalgarh, Jaisalmer, Ranthambhore (Sawai Madhopur), Gagron (Jhalawar) and Amber (Jaipur). The eclectic architecture of the forts, some up to 20 kilometres in circumference, bears testimony to the power of the Rajput princely states that flourished in the region from the 8th to the 18th centuries. Enclosed within the defensive walls are major urban centres, palaces, trading centres and other buildings including temples that often predate the fortifications within which developed an elaborate courtly culture that supported learning, music and the arts. The forts use the natural defenses offered by the landscape: hills, deserts, rivers, and dense forests. They also feature extensive water harvesting structures, largely still in use today. Besides these World Heritage forts, there are many other forts in Rajasthan, like Mehrangarh, Bala Qila, Junagarh Fort, Lohagarh, Nagaur, Shergarh, Kuchaman, Kishangarh, etc.

Painted havelis of Shekhawati

Shekhawati is a region filled with havelis which have works of art painted on them. That's why they call this region, which is named after Rao Shekha of the Kachhwaha clan of Amber, the 'open-air art gallery'. Today it comprises the districts of Jhunjhunu and Sikar. Towns like Mandawa and Churu in the Shekhawati region are home to exquisite painted havelis built by wealthy merchants. Shekhawati has temples and forts as well, such as Harsh Nath Temple, Lachmangarh, Ramgarh, Khatu Shyamji and so on.



Jain Temples

Rajasthan is home to many prominent Jain temples. Set in balmy Mount Abu and built between the 11th and 13th centuries, the Dilwara Jain temples are noted for their exquisite carvings, and the oldest is the Vimal Vasahi Temple. Shri Mahavir Ji Temple in Karauli District was built after an ancient idol of Mahavir was found in the soil several hundred years ago. Jaisalmer Fort is home to several magnificent Jain temples, including Chandraprabhu, Rikhabdev, Parasnath and Shitalnath temples. The 9th-century Lodurva Jain Temple near Jaislamer has astounding carvings. Soniji Ki Nasiyan, also called Ajmer Jain Temple, is a magnificent 19th-century temple with an inner chamber made of gold. The Osian Jain Temple in Jodhpur is one of the grandest. The Nakodaji Tirth in Barmer District is a prominent Jain temple famous for its architecture. The 15th -century Ranakpur Jain Temple dedicated to Adinatha is made with white marble in a chaumukha or four-faced design. The Tijara Jain Temple in Alwar District was established in 1956 following the recovery of an idol of Chandraprabha here.

Stepwells

A sophisticated system for water storage, the stepwells of Rajasthan are architectural marvels as well. Chand Baori (stepwell) in Abhaneri was built in the 9th century and is one of the largest stepwells in the world. Bundi is known for its many baoris, the largest being Raniji ki Baori which was built in 1699. The Mertani Ji ki Bawari in Jhunjhunu has a number of cool rooms accessible from the side. Jhunjhunu has the Khetano ki Bawadi as well. The Jodhpur Stepwell, known as Toorji ka Jhalra,